

SPIRITUAL OCCULTISTS

early 20th-century magical societies



▲ Glastonbury Tor

Glastonbury in southwest England became central to Dion Fortune's pursuit of mysticism. In 1924, she opened a spiritual retreat here, called Chalice Orchard.

During World War I, a young woman named Violet Mary Firth underwent an astonishing transformation. She was English, she lived in London, and she had a conventional upbringing. However, while training as a psychologist, she discovered a mystical, psychic world that changed her life. Firth became a proponent of the occult beliefs and esoteric thought that grew across Western Europe from the later 19th century. Her conviction was total—she was

certain that she was connected to a wisdom of the ages, part Christian, part psychic, and that she had been reincarnated multiple times.

Dion Fortune

In 1919, Violet Firth reemerged as Deo Non Fortuna (By God, Not Chance), shortened to Dion Fortune. That same year she became a member of the Theosophical Society (see p.239). Like her fellow members, she was convinced that she was in contact with the Ascended Masters (reincarnated enlightened beings). In a vision she even saw one of these beings, the “Master Jesus, Lord of Compassion,” guiding her to her own higher spirituality.

Fortune wrote numerous books, including guides to practical magic, an explanation of Kabbalah (see pp.136–39), and occult novels. Her greatest legacy, however, was the Society of the Inner Light, which she founded in 1927 in London.

Magic and mysticism

Dion Fortune was not alone. Besides belonging to the Theosophical Society, she was inspired by the Hermetic Order of the Golden Dawn (see pp.242–243). After that broke up acrimoniously at the end of the 19th century, Samuel Mathers founded the Rosicrucian Order of Alpha et Omega; his wife, artist-occultist Moina Mathers, directed it from 1918. Fortune joined the Order in 1919. Like members of the Fraternitas Saturni, launched by Eugen Grosche in Germany in 1926, Alpha et Omega members thought that magic and an understanding of the divine were the pathways to spiritualism.

Two further major esoteric movements, the Martinists, founded in France in 1889 (see pp.244–245), and the Fellowship of the Rosy Cross, created in England in 1915, were no less interested in the pursuit of divine origins and powers. However, they placed a premium on mysticism rather than magic. Both movements were explicitly Christian and believed in spiritual contemplation as the way of entering into the heart of God, and both continue to exist today.



GRIGORI RASPUTIN (1869–1916)

Mystic healer or charlatan?

At the same time as the spiritual developments of 19th-century Europe, the occult and alternatives to the Russian Orthodox Church, such as theosophy, fired the imaginations of the aristocracy in St. Petersburg. In 1903, Grigori Rasputin, born to a Siberian peasant family and claiming to be Christ reborn, entered high society in Russia's capital, and from 1905 he began to gain the trust of the Czarina. To her, Rasputin, with his claims of mystic healing powers, seemed the only hope for her hemophiliac son, Alexei. Rasputin was a bizarre character, a sexual predator driven by a belief in his own sanctity. His murder—he was poisoned, then shot, and eventually drowned—was as controversial as his life.